

Sanskrit, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

Sanskrit, like Latin, is not learned for conversation. It is learned to read, to hear how much of the world’s vocabulary was assembled, and — above all — because it is a **taproot**: the classical ancestor of Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali, whose every “hello” and “thank you” is a worn-down form of a Sanskrit word you will meet here in its full shape. And Sanskrit is at the same time a *sister* of Latin, Greek, and English — so its roots reach west (to *thee*, to Greek *eu-*, to *come*, to *no*) as surely as they reach east. Learning it ties the two halves of that inheritance together.

Sanskrit is classically written in **Devanagari**, the script you may already know from Hindi. This book teaches the reading *inside* the word lessons, with attention to the features Sanskrit needs even from a Devanagari reader — the *visarga* (ḥ), the vocalic ṛ, the conjuncts, and the *sandhi* that fuses words at their seams. (A reader new to the script learns it here from scratch; one who knows it skims the notes.)

We use standard **IAST** transliteration (the dotted ṛ, ḥ, ś, and macrons) alongside the Devanagari, and trace roots back toward Proto-Indo-European where the trail is clear — every form supplied in full. When Sir William Jones told the Asiatic Society in 1786 that Sanskrit bore to Latin and Greek “a stronger affinity... than could possibly have been produced by accident,” he launched the whole science of comparative linguistics; this book is, in miniature, a tour of the words he meant.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Sanskrit out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your*

turn are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Sanskrit greetings — and why they are the other **taproot** of the Indo-Aryan family. Every “thank you” and “hello” in the Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali tracks points back here; and Sanskrit is at the same time a *sister* of Latin, Greek, and English, so its words reach west as well as east. Each lesson introduces the letters and the Sanskrit-specific reading its word needs.

1.1 नमस्ते (*namaste*) — “I bow to you”

The letters in this word

Devanagari runs **left to right** under a top line; every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न *na*, म *ma*, ते *te* (त + the *e*-sign े). A *hasanta* under स् strips its vowel so it joins the next: स् + त → स्त. Read नमस्ते as *na · ma · s · te*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्ते = *namas* (“a bow, obeisance”) + *te* (“to you”) — literally “**a bow to you**.” This is the *original*: the word every Indo-Aryan *namaste* descends from — Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali all say a worn form of it. *Namas* comes from the root √*nam* “to bend, bow,” from Proto-Indo-European **nem-* “to allot, take.” And *te* “to you” is a family heirloom: the same Indo-European pronoun behind Latin *tē*, Greek *se*, and archaic English **thee**. Say *namas-te* and you are speaking a word Cicero and Chaucer would each have half-recognised.

Why it's said this way

Palms pressed together (the gesture is *añjali*), a slight bow: the hands and the word say the same thing. *Namaste* greets the person before you as worthy of a bow — hello, and, when parting, goodbye. It is the greeting Sanskrit gave to half of South Asia.

1.2 नमस्कारः (*namaskārah*) — the fuller form**The letters in this word**

New: का *kā* (क + the ā-sign ा), र *ra*, and the **visarga** ः — a soft breathed “h” at a word’s end, written as two dots. नमस्कारः = *namaskārah*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कारः = *namas* (“a bow”) + *kāra* (“the making, the doing,” from the root *√kr* “to do/make”). So *namaskāra* is “the **making** of a bow” — an act, where *namaste* is an address. That root *√kr* “to do” is one of the most productive in Sanskrit (it gives *karma*, “a thing done”); it is the Indo-European **kwer-* and a distant cousin of English *-ory/-ure* words of making. The final **visarga** *-ah* is the mark of the masculine singular — your first case-ending.

Grammar Lens

Namaste and *namaskāra* share the same first half, *namas*, but end differently because they *do* different grammatical jobs — one takes a pronoun (*te* “to you”), the other builds a noun (*-kāra* “the making of”). Sanskrit words are transparently assembled from roots and endings like this; once you see the seams, long words stop being frightening.

1.3 धन्यवादः (*dhanyavādaḥ*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ध *dha* (breathy *d*), व *va*, द *da*, and the conjunct न्य (न + य *ya*).
With the visarga again, read धन्यवादः as *dha · nya · vā · daḥ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवादः = *dhanya* (“worthy, deserving,” from *dhana* “wealth”) + *vāda* (“a speaking, a statement,” from the root *√vad* “to speak”). Literally “a saying of “you are worthy.”” This is the *source* of the thanks you met to the east — Hindi *dhanyavād*, Marathi and Punjabi likewise — here in its full, un-worn Sanskrit shape, visarga and all.

1.4 स्वागतम् (*svāgatam*) — “welcome”

The letters in this word

New: the conjunct स्व (स् + व *va*) = *sva*, ग *ga*, and the *halant* म् *m* closing the word with no vowel. Read स्वागतम् as *svā · ga · tam*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

स्वागतम् = *su* (“well, good”) + *āgata* (“come,” from *ā* “toward” + the root *√gam* “to go/come”) — “**well come**,” which is exactly what English *welcome* means too. Two deep Indo-European threads surface here:

- *su*- “good” is the twin of **Greek eu-** — the *eu* of *euphoria*, *eulogy*, *euphemism*. Sanskrit *su-gata* and Greek *eu-* are the same prefix.
- the root *√gam* “to go/come” is the Indo-European **gʷem-* — the very root of English **come** (and of Latin *venire*, hence *venue*, *con-vene*).

So *svāgatam* and *welcome* are not just parallel ideas but partly *cognate* ones.

1.5 आम् / न (*ām* / *na*) — “yes” and “no”

The letters in this word

New: आ — the **independent** vowel ā (the shape for a word-initial vowel) — closed by the halant म् *m*: आम् *ām*. And न *na*, a single consonant with its built-in “a.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आम् (*ām*, “yes”) and न (*na*, “no, not”). That *na* is a word you have already met wearing other clothes: it is Proto-Indo-European **ne* “not,” **the same negative** as the Latin *nōn* of the last track, as English **no**, **not**, **none**, as German *nein*, and as Hindi *nahīn*. Of all the words in this book, *na* may be the one that reaches furthest unchanged: one tiny syllable spoken, in some form, from Iceland to India for five thousand years.

Why it’s said this way

Classical Sanskrit, like Latin, leans on more than a bare “yes”: one often answers by echoing the verb, or with *ām*, *evam* (“so it is”), or *bāḍham* (“certainly”). The blunt yes/no habit of English is not universal — these old languages preferred to *say what they meant*.

1.6 Recap

Sanskrit		Meaning
नमस्ते	<i>namaste</i>	hello (“a bow to you”)
नमस्कारः	<i>namaskārah</i>	hello (“the making of a bow”)
धन्यवादः	<i>dhanyavādaḥ</i>	thank you
स्वागतम्	<i>svāgatam</i>	welcome (“well come”)
आम् / न	<i>ām</i> / <i>na</i>	yes / no

Sanskrit is the eastern taproot: *namas*, *dhanya-vāda*, and the bow that survives, worn smooth, as every Indo-Aryan hello and thank-you. But look which way its roots also point — *te* “to you” toward English *thee*, *su-* “good” toward Greek *eu-*, *√gam* toward *come*, *na* toward *no* and Latin *nōn*. When Sir William Jones noticed in 1786 that Sanskrit, Latin, and Greek were kin, *these* are the kinds of words he meant. Next chapter: introducing yourself

— *mama nāma...* (“my name...”) — and Sanskrit’s astonishing verb, which marks person, number, *and* how many are speaking.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — and, since this is Sanskrit, each atom is the *ancestor* of words across both Europe and modern India:

मम नाम अरुणः अस्ति। (mama nāma Aruṇaḥ asti — “My name is Arun.”)
तव नाम किम्? (tava nāma kim — “What is your name?”)

2.1 नाम (*nāma*) — “name,” the source of a word half the world shares

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाम (*nāma*, “name”) is from the stem *nāman*, from Proto-Indo-European *h₃nómn̥. This is not a borrowing but the *ancestor*: English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**), Greek *onoma*, and, worn down, Hindi *nām*, Bengali *nām*. Saying *nāma*, you stand near the headwaters of a word that flowed to both Europe and modern India.

2.2 मम (*mama*) — “my,” the ancestor of *me* and *my*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मम (*mama*, “my, of me”) is the genitive of अहम् (*aham*, “I”), on the first-person root *ma-*, PIE *me- — the source of English **me**, **my**, **mine**, Latin *meus*, and Hindi *merā*. Sanskrit *mama* and English *my* are the same ancient word, one still in its old form.

2.3 अस्ति (*asti*) — “is,” the ancestor of *is* and *est*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अस्ति (*asti*, “is”) is the third person of the root अस् (*as-*, “to be”), PIE *h₁es- — the source of English **is**, Latin *est*, Greek *esti*, and Hindi *hai* (from *asti* directly). Unlike its Dravidian neighbours (Tamil and Bengali drop “is”), Sanskrit *keeps* an explicit copula — the word Europe kept too.

2.4 मम नाम ...अस्ति — “my name is...”

मम (my) + नाम (name) + name + अस्ति (is) = “my name is...” The verb comes last.

Grammar Lens

Sanskrit keeps the “is.” Tamil says only *en peyar Arun*, Bengali *āmār nām Arun* — both dropping the verb. Sanskrit says *mama nāma ...asti*, with an explicit *asti* — the Indo-European way, kept by Latin and English too.

2.5 भवान् and त्वम् (*bhavān*, *tvam*) — “you,” respectful and familiar

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

त्वम् (*tvam*, familiar “you”) is from PIE *tū — the ancestor of English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, Hindi *tū*. भवान् (*bhavān*, respectful) is really a third-person honorific, “your honour” (from *bhavat*), and so takes a *third-person* verb.

Grammar Lens

Politeness by grammatical person. Where Hindi makes respect *plural* (*āp ...haiṃ*), Sanskrit makes it *third-person*: you address someone as though speaking *about* them — “is your honour well?”

2.6 किम् (*kim*) — “what,” root of many question-words

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

किम् (*kim*, “what”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the ancestor of English **what**, **who**, Latin *quis*, and Hindi *kyā*. Sanskrit’s own questions all grow from this *ka-*: *kim* (what), *kaḥ* (who), *kadā* (when), *kutra* (where), *katham* (how) — the single seed of both Europe’s *qu-/wh-* and India’s *k-* words.

2.7 तव नाम किम्? — “what’s your name?”

तव (*tava*, “your,” genitive of *tvam*) + नाम (name) + किम् (what) = “your name what?” Here Sanskrit often drops *asti*. Respectfully: भवतः नाम किम्? (*bhavataḥ nāma kim?*). Note *mama* / *tava* / *bhavataḥ* — “my / your / your-honour’s,” all genitives.

2.8 आनन्दः (*ānandaḥ*) — “joy,” and “a joy to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

To say “pleased to meet you,” Sanskrit can say भवन्तं दृष्ट्वा आनन्दः (*bhavantaṁ dr̥ṣṭvā ānandaḥ*) — “seeing you, [there is] joy.” आनन्दः (*ānandaḥ*, “joy, bliss”) is *ā-* (“fully”) + नन्द् (*nand*, “to rejoice”) — the *ānanda* of *sat-cit-ānanda* (“being-consciousness-bliss”) and the name **Ānanda**, the Buddha’s disciple. A simple greeting reaches for the word Indian thought uses for the deepest happiness.

2.9 The whole exchange

Sanskrit	English
मम नाम मीरा अस्ति।	My name is Mira.
तव नाम किम्?	What's your name?
मम नाम अरुणः अस्ति।	My name is Arun.
भवन्तं दृष्ट्वा आनन्दः।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom is a *source*: *nāma* ($\rightarrow$ *name*), *mama* ($\rightarrow$ *my*), *asti* ($\rightarrow$ *is*), *kim* ($\rightarrow$ *what*). And Sanskrit keeps the copula its Dravidian neighbours drop. Next chapter: *bhavān katham asti?* (“how are you?”).

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — carried by the copula whose forms fathered English *am* and *is*:

भवान् कथम् अस्ति? (*bhavān katham asti* — “How are you?”)
अहं कुशली अस्मि, धन्यवादः। (*ahaṃ kuśalī asmi, dhanyavādah* — “I am well, thank you.”)

3.1 कथम् (*katham*) — “how,” another of the ka-questions

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कथम् (*katham*, “how”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE *k^wo- — the root behind English **wh**- and Latin *qu*-. It heads the same *ka*- family (*kim*, *kaḥ*, *kadā*, *kutra*, *katham*), and gives the noun *kathā* (“a telling, a story”) and, worn down, Hindi’s *kaise*.

3.2 भवान् कथम् अस्ति? — “how are you?”

भवान् (*bhavān*, respectful “you”) + कथम् (how) + अस्ति (is) = “your honour how is?” Recall that *bhavān* (“your honour”) takes a **third-person** verb — so *asti* (“is”), not “are.” Familiar: त्वं कथम् असि? (*tvaṃ katham asi?*).

Grammar Lens

The copula, three persons: अस्मि (*asmi*, “I am”), असि (*asi*, “you are”), अस्ति (*asti*, “is”) — ancestors of English **am** and (via Latin/Greek)

is/est. “How are you?” asks after a *state*, and Sanskrit always kept a verb for it.

3.3 अहम् (*aham*) — “I,” the ancestor of *ego* and *I*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अहम् (*aham*, “I”) is from PIE *h₁eǵ(H)om — the ancestor of Latin **ego**, Greek *egō*, and, worn all the way down, English **I**. Sanskrit *aham*, Latin *ego*, English *I* are one word across time. Its possessive is *mama* (“my”); curiously, “I” and “my” come from *different* roots (*eǵ- and *me-) — a quirk Sanskrit shares with English (*I* vs. *my*).

3.4 कुशलम् (*kuśalam*) — “well-being,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कुशलम् (*kuśalam*, “well-being, welfare”) is native Sanskrit, famously from कुश (*kuśa*, the sacred grass) + a root of “cutting”: first “skilled [at gathering *kuśa* properly],” hence “adept, fit, in good order,” hence “well.” The reply: अहं कुशली अस्मि (*aham kuśalī asmi*), “I am well.”

3.5 न चिन्ता (*na cintā*) — “no worry”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

न चिन्ता literally “[there is] **no** worry” — न (*na*, “not,” from Chapter 1) + चिन्ता (*cintā*, “anxious thought,” from the root *cint* “to think”). Used for “never mind / you’re welcome.” *Na* is the ancient negative, PIE *ne, behind English **no**, **not**, Latin *nōn*; *cintā* is the same worry borrowed into Hindi (*cintā mat karo*). “Think nothing of it.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Sanskrit	English
भवान् कथम् अस्ति?	How are you?
अहं कुशली अस्मि, धन्यवादः।	I am well, thank you.
न चिन्ता।	No worry / you're welcome.

The taproot, both ways: *katham* (*ka-*, → English *how*), *aham* (→ Latin *ego*, English *I*), the copula *asmi* / *asti* (→ *am* / *is*), and *na* (→ *no*, Latin *nōn*). Next chapter: the farewells.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Sanskrit has no casual “bye.” Like its daughters, it takes leave by “I go” — and promises a seeing to come:

पुनर्दर्शनाय। (*punar-darśanāya* — “Until we meet again.”)

4.1 गच्छामि (*gacchāmi*) — “I go” (taking leave)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

गच्छामि (*gacchāmi*, “I go”) is from the root गम् (*gam*, “to go”) — the root inside Chapter 1’s स्वागतम् (*svāgatam* = *su* + *āgata*, “well come”). That root is PIE *g^wem-, the ancestor of English **come**. To leave politely one says *gacchāmi* (“I go”) or *āgacchāmi* (“I shall come [back]”) — the “promise of return” the modern languages kept.

4.2 पुनः (*punaḥ*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पुनः (*punaḥ*, “again, once more”) is a native adverb (combining form *punar-*, as in *punar-janma*, “rebirth”). No single English cognate, but its work is shared: it turns a parting into “see you *again*.”

4.3 पुनर्दर्शनाय (*punar-darśanāya*) — “until we meet again”

पुनर् (*punar*, “again”) + दर्शनाय (*darśanāya*, “for seeing”) = “for seeing [you] again.” The word दर्शन (*darśana*, “seeing, vision”) is deep: the *darśan* one takes of a deity, and the name of the six *darśanas*, the schools of Indian philosophy (“ways of seeing”). This farewell promises a *beholding* to come.

Grammar Lens

The dative “for the sake of.” The ending -आय (-*āya*) is the dative singular — “to / for.” *Darśana* (a seeing) → *darśanāya* (for a seeing). Your first case.

4.4 श्वः (*śvaḥ*) — “tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

श्वः (*śvaḥ*, “tomorrow”) is from PIE *kes-. Where the modern languages muddle “tomorrow” and “yesterday” into one word (Hindi *kal*, Bengali *kāl*, from *kāla* “time”), classical Sanskrit kept them *separate*: *śvaḥ* is “tomorrow,” *hyaḥ* is “yesterday.” “See you tomorrow” is श्वः पुनर्दर्शनम् (*śvaḥ punar-darśanam*).

Grammar Lens

That the daughters blurred *śvaḥ* / *hyaḥ* into a single *kal* is a window into language change: the modern tongues traded precision for economy, letting tense carry the load.

4.5 The farewells

Sanskrit	English
गच्छामि।	I go. (taking leave)
पुनर्दर्शनाय।	Until we meet again.
श्वः पुनर्दर्शनम्।	See you tomorrow.

Roots banked: *gam* “to go” (→ English **come**), *punah* “again” (→ *punar-janma*), *darśana* “a beholding,” and *śvaḥ* / *hyaḥ* — “tomorrow” / “yester-

day,” kept apart. Next chapter: the first real verbs — and Sanskrit’s count to *three*.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and the most famous feature of the Sanskrit verb: it counts to **three**.

अहं संस्कृतं वदामि। (aḥaṃ saṃskṛtaṃ vadāmi — “I speak Sanskrit.”)

5.1 वदामि (*vadāmi*) — “I speak,” and the Sanskrit verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

वदामि (*vadāmi*, “I speak”) is from the root वद् (*vad*, “to speak”) — the root of वाद (*vāda*, “a saying”) inside Chapter 1’s धन्यवादः (*dhanyavādaḥ*). The present is stem + ending: *vad-ā-mi*, where *-mi* means “I” (the same *-mi* as in *asmi*, “I am”).

Grammar Lens

Singular, dual, plural. Where English and Hindi count in two, Sanskrit counts in **three**, with a **dual** for exactly two:

number	form	meaning
singular	<i>vadāmi</i>	I speak
dual	<i>vadāvah</i>	we two speak
plural	<i>vadāmaḥ</i>	we (three or more) speak

A whole number just for pairs — two eyes, two hands, a couple. Greek had it and lost it; English never kept it; Sanskrit polished it.

5.2 अहं संस्कृतं वदामि — “I speak Sanskrit”

अहम् (I) + संस्कृतम् (the object) + वदामि (speak) — “I Sanskrit speak,” verb last. The name संस्कृत (saṃskṛta) means “**put together, perfected**” — सम् (sam-, “together,” cousin of English *same*, Greek *syn-*) + कृत (kṛta, “made,” from *kr*). Named in contrast to *prākṛta* (“natural, raw” — Prakrit, the everyday speech from which Hindi, Bengali, and the rest descend).

Grammar Lens

Sandhi joins the words. *aham* + *saṃskṛtam* runs together as *ahaṃ saṃskṛtam* — the *m* softening to the anusvāra. That is *sandhi*, met in Chapter 1’s *svāgatam*; it is why Sanskrit flows.

5.3 वसामि (*vasāmi*) — “I live, I dwell”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

वसामि (*vasāmi*, “I dwell, live”) is from the root वस् (*vas*, “to dwell”), PIE *wes- — the ancestor of English **was** and **were** (the past of “to be” began as “to dwell/remain”). From *vas* come *vāsa* (“a dwelling”), *nivāsa* (“a residence”), *Vārāṇasī*. “I live in the city” is अहं नगरे वसामि (*ahaṃ nagare vasāmi*).

Grammar Lens

“In” is a case-ending. नगरे (*nagare*, “in the city”) = *nagara* in the **locative** (-e, “in/at”). Sanskrit has no separate word for “in” — it is folded into the noun’s ending, the ancestor of Hindi’s and Bengali’s postpositions.

5.4 करोमि (*karomi*) — “I do,” from the root behind *karma*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करोमि (*karomi*, “I do, make”) is from the root कृ (*kr*, “to do”), PIE *k^wer- — the root at the heart of this book: *namaskāraḥ* (“the *making* of a bow”), *karma* (“a thing *done*”), *saṃskṛta* (“*put together*”). “I work” is कार्य करोमि (*kāryaṃ karomi*) — and कार्यम् (*kāryam*, “work”) is *itself* from *kr*. So “I work” is, at root, “*kr*-thing I *kr*-do.” Hindi’s *kām karnā* and Bengali’s *kāj karā* are its worn-down grandchildren.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Sanskrit	English
अहं संस्कृतं वदामि।	I speak Sanskrit.
अहं नगरे वसामि।	I live in the city.
अहं कार्यं करोमि।	I work.
वदावः।	We two speak. (the dual)

Three verbs, one engine (the *-mi* “I”), the verb always last, “in” folded into a case-ending — and a whole number, the **dual**, for exactly two. Roots banked: *vad* (speak → *dhanyavāda*), *vas* (dwell → English **was**), *kr* (do → *namaskāra*, *karma*, *saṃskṛta*). From here, Sanskrit — the source these tracks all point back to — only opens further.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Sanskrit numerals एक to पञ्च with their dual and gendered forms, and follow पञ्च outward into Punjab, pentagon, and the disputed history of punch.

Trace pañca out of Sanskrit: into Persian panj-āb, the five waters behind Punjab; into Greek pente in pentagon and pentathlon; and into punch, with the five-ingredients account labelled as common rather than settled.

6.1 एक, द्व, त्रि, चतुर, पञ्च — one to five

This chapter does something the other Indic chapters can't do alone. Sanskrit preserves the **Old Indo-Aryan forms behind** the Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Gujarati and Punjabi ones — and, at the same time, these forms are **cousins** of the English ones. Learn five and you get a foothold in both directions.

You'll want to know: the five

	stem	masculine	neuter
1	éka-	एकः ékaḥ	एकम् ékam
2	dvá-	द्वौ dváu	द्वे dvé
3	tri-	त्रयः trayaḥ	त्रीणि trīṇi
4	catúr-	चत्वारः catvāraḥ	चत्वारि catvāri
5	पञ्च pāñca	—	—

Three notes, and the third one matters more than it looks.

Sanskrit has a dual — a separate number for exactly two things — which is why “two” is *dváu* rather than a plural.

***Pañca* barely inflects in the nominative and accusative. It is also the one you already half-know.**

And Sanskrit numbers have gender. Look at the last column. These same words, in Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Gujarati, and Punjabi, mostly descend from the **neuter** forms — *trīṇi* and *catvāri*, not *tráyaḥ* and *catvāraḥ*. Keep that column in view; the daughter languages inherit from it.

What you’ve built: two directions

These five forms point in two directions. The next lesson lines them up with Latin and English and explains the sound laws. A final short lesson follows *pañca* into *Punjab*, *pentagon*, and the qualified history of *punch*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca”
- the exactly-two category — dual
- the daughter-language column — neuter

Before you move on

Give one to five in Sanskrit. (*Eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca.*) Why does “two” look unusual? (Sanskrit has a **dual** — a form for exactly two.) Which column will the modern languages mostly descend from? (**The neuter** — *trīṇi, catvāri.*) Which number barely changes across gender in this table? (*Pañca.*) Next: connect the Sanskrit forms west to Latin and English.

6.2 The Sanskrit numbers are English cousins

Give the five stems: *eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca.*

What you’ve built: one family, not borrowing

Sanskrit	Latin	English
<i>éka-</i>	<i>ūnus</i>	one
<i>dvá-</i>	<i>duo</i>	two
<i>tri-</i>	<i>trēs</i>	three
<i>catúr-</i>	<i>quattuor</i>	four
<i>páñca</i>	<i>quīnque</i>	five

Sanskrit, Latin, and English inherited these from one family. Numbers resist replacement, so their relationship remains audible after millennia. The first row needs one caveat: *éka-* and *ūnus/one* use the same root with different suffixes, PIE **oy-ko-* versus **óynos*. They are relatives rather than the same complete word. The other four rows continue the same word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

PIE **k^w* was a *k* with rounded lips. In **k^wetwóres* “four,” three branches treated it differently:

branch	outcome	example
Latin	kept <i>qu-</i>	<i>quattuor</i>
Indo-Iranian	merged it with <i>k</i> , then palatalised before front vowels	<i>catvāri</i>
Germanic	shifted it to <i>hw-</i>	<i>what, who</i>

Sanskrit *c-* is therefore a regular result, not a random replacement. The same sequence helps explain *pañca*’s *ñc*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **f**- of *five* does not come from **k^w*. It comes from initial **p*, changed to *f* by **Grimm’s law**, as in *pater* → *father* and *pēs* → *foot*.

English *four* is irregular. By the sound rule it should begin *hw-* like *what*. Its *f-* is usually explained as analogy with neighbouring *five*. Counting words can reshape one another.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tri*, *trēs*, *three*
- rounded *k* — *quattuor*, *catvāri*, *what*
- initial *p* → *f* — *pañca*/*five*
- regular inheritance or borrowing — inheritance

Before you move on

Are the Latin and Sanskrit forms borrowed from one another? (No: they are inherited cousins.) What are the three outcomes of $*k^w$? (Latin *qu-*, Indo-Iranian *c-* after merger and palatalisation, Germanic *hw-*.) Where does *five*'s initial *f* come from? (PIE *p* by Grimm's law.) What is the usual explanation for *four* also beginning with *f*? (Analogy with neighbouring *five*.)

6.3 *Pañca* hiding in familiar words

Say Sanskrit “five.” (*Pañca*.) Give its English cousin. (*Five*.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Punjab comes from Persian *pañj-āb*, “five waters,” for the land of five rivers spanning India and Pakistan. Persian *pañj* is the Iranian cousin of Indic *pañca*: both descend from the same Indo-Iranian and PIE number root.

The place-name is Persian, not Sanskrit, but the family resemblance is real.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Greek **pente** is another descendant of the same root. It appears in **pentagon**, a five-sided figure, and **pentathlon**, a five-event contest.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The usual account derives **punch**, the drink, from Hindi *pāñich* ← Sanskrit *pañca*, because the drink was said to contain five ingredients.

That origin is not unanimous. A rival derives the word from **puncheon**, a type of cask. Keep the useful connection with a label: “the common five-ingredients account,” not an unquestioned fact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pañ* + *āb* — five waters
- Greek *pente* — pentagon, pentathlon
- *punch* — common account, not certain

Before you move on

What does *Punjab* mean? (“Five waters.”) Is Persian *pañ* borrowed from Sanskrit? (No: it is an Iranian cousin.) Which Greek form hides in *pentagon*? (*Pente*.) What caution belongs with the drink *punch*? (The five-ingredients derivation is common, but *puncheon* is a rival account.)

Chapter 7

The Core Verbs

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone is, becomes, goes, comes, eats, sees and knows in Sanskrit; I can name each verb by its dhātu rather than by its present form, say which of the three gaṇa patterns builds its stem, and point at the English word that descends from the same root.

Say जानाति, name its root ज्ञा and the syllable -ना- its class plants inside the word, run back through the chapter’s six verbs as root plus class plus ending, separate the one that is a prefixed form of another, and pair गम्, अद्, पश् and भू with come, eat, inspect and be.

7.1 अस्ति and भवति — Sanskrit’s two words for “is”

Six chapters of words. Now the machinery. A Sanskrit verb is never quoted the way an English one is, and this pair shows why.

You’ll want to know: अस्ति and भवति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
अस्ति	<i>asti</i>	he, she, or it is
भवति	<i>bhavati</i>	he, she, or it becomes

Both land in English as “is.” *Asti* states that something simply **is** there. *Bhavati* says something **comes to be** — a state arriving rather than sitting still. Sanskrit never merged the two.

The letters in this word

अ is *a*, a short neutral vowel; ति is *tī*. Inside अस्ति the *s* and *t* stack into one joined shape, स्ति — Devanagari fuses a consonant cluster into a single letter. भवति needs no fusing: भ *bha*, व *va*, ति *tī*.

Grammar Lens: the dhātu and its gaṇa

Sanskrit files a verb under its धातु (*dhātu*), its **root** — the bare syllable a dictionary lists. *Asti* is filed under अस् (*as*), *bhavati* under भू (*bhū*). A root is not yet a word. To reach the present it joins one of ten गण (*gaṇa*) classes, and the class decides what happens between root and ending. Class 2 adds nothing: *as* + *tī* → *asti*. Class 1 strengthens the root and adds a vowel: *bhū* → *bhava* + *tī* → *bhavati*. Root, then class, then ending. Every verb in this chapter is built that way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अस् is PIE **es-*: English **is**, Latin *est*, German *ist*, barely worn. भू is PIE **bheu-*, “to grow, to come to be”: English **be** and **been**, Latin *futūrus* behind **future**, Greek *phusis* behind **physics**. Now the surprise. English “to be” is stitched from *both* — *am*, *is*, *are* from **es-*; *be*, *been*, *being* from **bheu-*. English fused two verbs into one ragged paradigm. Sanskrit left them side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “asti” — it is
- “bhavati” — it becomes
- the two roots — *as*, *bhū*
- the English halves — “is” from one, “been” from the other

Before you move on

Which two roots stand behind *asti* and *bhavati*? (अस् *as* and भू *bhū*.)
What does a गण class do? (**Turns a root into a present stem** —

nothing added for *as*, a vowel added for *bhū*.) Which English words descend from each? (*Is* from *as*; *be* and *been* from *bhū*.) Next: a root whose present stem you could never have guessed.

7.2 गच्छति (gacchati) — “goes,” and why dictionaries file it elsewhere

Root, then class, then ending. Say the two roots from last time. (*As*, *bhū*.) Here the middle step stops being tidy.

You’ll want to know: गच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गच्छति	<i>gacchati</i>	he, she, or it goes
गच्छामि	<i>gacchāmi</i>	I go

The second form is already yours: Chapter 4 used it to take leave. Same stem, different ending — -ति *-ti* for “he, she, it,” -मि *-āmi* for “I.”

The letters in this word

ग is *ga*. ति is *ti*, already familiar. Between them sits च्छ, a doubled *ch* — one stacked shape for two *ch* sounds in a row, held slightly long: *gach-cha*. Let the middle of the word linger.

Grammar Lens: the stem that hides its root

The root here is गम् (*gam*), “to go.” The present stem is गच्छ (*gaccha*). No rule you have met turns one into the other, and no amount of staring at *gaccha* recovers *gam*.

That is the whole reason Sanskrit hangs its grammar on the root rather than on any spoken form. *Gam* is where the dictionary keeps this verb, where its past and future are built from, and where its relatives — गति *gati* “motion,” आगम *āgama* “arrival” — are visibly cousins. Learn roots, not forms.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

गम् is PIE **gwem-*. Its English descendant is **come** — the same root, turned around: what one language walks away with, another walks toward.

Latin took it as *venīre*, “to come,” and English then borrowed it back in a crowd: **venue**, **convene**, **intervene**, **advent**, **adventure**. Sanskrit *gacchati* and English *come* are the two ends of one very old word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gacchati” — it goes
- “gacchāmi” — I go
- the root, not the stem — *gam*
- the English cousin — *come*

Before you move on

What is the root of *gacchati*? (गम् *gam*.) Could you have predicted the stem from it? (**No** — which is why the root is what gets learned.) Which ending makes it “I go”? (-ामि *-āmi*.) Which English verb is the same root? (**Come**.) Next: the same stem, aimed the other way.

7.3 आगच्छति (āgacchati) — “comes,” or “goes” reversed

Say “it goes.” (*Gacchati*.) Now add one syllable in front and the direction reverses.

You’ll want to know: आगच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गच्छति	<i>gacchati</i>	it goes
आगच्छति	<i>āgacchati</i>	it comes

आ (ā) means “toward, hither.” Stick it on the front and the motion turns back to face you. Sanskrit has no separate word for “come” at all: coming is going, aimed homeward.

The letters in this word

Everything after the first letter is last lesson’s word, unchanged. The new piece is आ, the long ā — the same vowel as अ a but held roughly twice as long. Length alone carries meaning in Sanskrit, so give it its time: *aa-gach-cha-ti*.

Grammar Lens: the upasarga, Sanskrit’s aiming device

आ is an उपसर्ग (*upasarga*), a preverb. Sanskrit has about twenty, and any of them may ride in front of a root to re-aim it:

prefix	sense	on गम्
आ ā	toward	āgacchati, comes
सम् sam	together	samigacchati, goes together
नि ni	down	nigacchati, goes down

A handful of roots plus a handful of prefixes covers an enormous amount of vocabulary. You have met the trick already without being told: संस्कृत (*saṁskṛta*, “Sanskrit”) is *sam* “together” on the root कृ *kr* “make” — put-together, and so perfected.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Latin aims *venīre* “come” with the same kind of prefix: *ad-* “toward” gives **advent**, *con-* “with” gives **convene**, *inter-* “between” gives **intervene**. English does it natively too — *come* becomes **become**, **overcome**, **income**.

Sanskrit simply runs the system harder and more openly, with the seams left visible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gacchati ... āgacchati” — goes, comes
- the prefix and its sense — ā, toward

- one more prefix on the same root — *sam*, together

Before you move on

How does Sanskrit say “comes”? (आगच्छति — *ā* “toward” on “goes.”)
 What is such a prefix called? (An उपसर्ग, *upasarga*.) Which Sanskrit
 word you already knew is built the same way? (संस्कृत — *sam* plus *kṛ*.)
 Next: a verb whose everyday form is not the one related to English.

7.4 खादति (khādati) — “eats,” and the cousin it is not

Name the three steps that build a Sanskrit present. (**Root, class, ending**.) This verb is the tidiest one yet — and hides a warning.

You’ll want to know: खादति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
खादति	<i>khādati</i>	he, she, or it eats
खाद्य	<i>khādyā</i>	edible , food

The root is खाद् (*khād*), and it belongs to the same class 1 as *bhū*, so the build is plain: *khād* + *a* + *ti* → *khādati*. No stacked letters, no surprises, nothing hidden.

The letters in this word

खा is *khā*: a *k* with a puff of breath after it, then the long *ā* you met last lesson. Sanskrit treats that puff as a separate letter, not an accent — क *ka* and ख *kha* are two different letters that change meaning. द is *da*, ति is *ti*.

Grammar Lens: the everyday word and the related word

English **eat**, Latin *edere* (behind **edible**), and German *essen* all descend from PIE **ed-*. Sanskrit inherited it too, as the root अद् (*ad*), class 2 — endings straight onto the root, like *asti*: *ad* + *ti* → अस्ति (*atti*), “eats.” But *atti* is not the ordinary word. Classical Sanskrit eats with खाद्, a root with no clear European relative at all.

So the family word and the everyday word part company here. Cognates tell you where a language came from; they do not promise to tell you what it says at dinner. Keep the two questions separate.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The pattern repeats across the family. English has native **eat** beside borrowed **consume** and **devour**; Sanskrit has inherited अद् beside ordinary खाद्.

A language keeps its old word somewhere — in a proverb, a compound, a sacred text — while daily speech moves on to another. *Khādyā*, “edible,” is the word you will actually meet on a menu.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “khādati” — it eats
- the root and its class build — *khād ... a ... ti*
- the cousin of English *eat* — *ad, atti*

Before you move on

What is the ordinary Sanskrit verb for eating? (खादति, *khādati*, root खाद्.) Which Sanskrit root is the actual cousin of English *eat*? (अद् *ad*, giving *atti*.) Which class does *ad* belong to, and how do you know? (Class 2 — the ending goes straight onto the root, as in *asti*.) Next: a verb built out of two different roots.

7.5 पश्यति (paśyati) — “sees,” a verb with two roots

So far one root has built each verb. Here two roots share the work, and you have already met the quieter one.

You'll want to know: पश्यति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पश्यति	<i>paśyati</i>	he, she, or it sees
दर्शन	<i>darśana</i>	a beholding , a viewing

The present tense comes from the root पश् (paś). Every other tense of this verb comes from a different root, दृश् (dṛś) — and dṛś is where दर्शन was built, the word inside Chapter 4's farewell पुनर्दर्शनाय, “until a seeing again.”

Two roots, one verb, divided by tense. English does the same with *go* and *went*, which were never the same verb either.

The letters in this word

प is *pa*. Then श्य, a stack of two letters: श *śa*, a *sh* made with the tongue high and forward, plus य *ya*. Say them glued: *pash-ya-ti*. Sanskrit has three different *s* letters, and this is the one that leans toward *sh*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पश् descends from PIE **spek-*, “to observe closely.” The *s* and the *p* swapped places on the way into Indo-Iranian, which is why the Sanskrit form begins *paś-* rather than *spaś-*.

Latin kept it straight as *specere*, and English is full of the results: **spectacle, inspect, respect, species, suspect, spy**.

Greek swapped the letters too, in its own direction, giving *skop-*: **telescope, microscope, skeptic, bishop** (from *episkopos*, an overseer).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “paśyati” — it sees
- the two roots — *paś* for the present, *dṛś* for the rest
- the Chapter 4 word from the other root — *darśana*
- the English descendants — *inspect, species, telescope*

Before you move on

Which root gives the present *paśyati*? (पश् *paś*.) Which root supplies the rest of the verb? (दृश् *drś* — the one behind *darśana*.) What PIE root is *paś* from? (**Spek-*.) Name two English words from it. (**Inspect**, **species**, **telescope** — any two.) Next: the verb that means “know,” and the class that plants a syllable in the middle.

7.6 जानाति (jānāti) — “knows,” and English *know* is the same word

Two ways a root has become a stem so far: nothing added, or a vowel added. Here is the third, and it is the boldest.

You’ll want to know: जानाति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
जानाति	<i>jānāti</i>	he, she, or it knows
ज्ञान	<i>jñāna</i>	knowledge

The root is ज्ञा (*jñā*). Its class, the ninth, does not add a vowel at the end — it plants a whole syllable -ना- (-*nā*-) between root and ending: *jā* + *nā* + *ti* → *jānāti*. The marker sits inside the word.

The letters in this word

ज्ञा is *jā*; ना *nā* and ति *ti* close it. The root’s own spelling ज्ञ is a famous stacked letter, *j* over *ñ*, said *gya* across much of India today and *jñā* in the classical description. Pick one and stay with it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ज्ञा is PIE **gno-*. English **know** is that root undisguised, and so are **can** and **cunning**, which began as “know how.”

Latin took it as *noscere*: **notice**, **notion**, **cognition**, **ignore** (“not-know”), **noble** (“well-known”). Greek took it as *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, **agnostic**.

One root, a whole shelf of English vocabulary, and Sanskrit ज्ञान *jñāna* sitting at the other end of it.

What you've built: six verbs, three ways to build a stem

Asti, bhavati, gacchati, āgacchati, khādati, paśyati, jñāti. Every one is a root plus a class plus an ending, and the class was the only thing that varied: nothing inserted (*as-ti*), a vowel appended (*bhava-ti, khāda-ti*), or a syllable planted inside (*jñā-nā-ti*). Prefix one and you aim it: *ā-gacchati*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jñāti” — it knows
- the root and its planted syllable — *jñā ... nā*
- the English twin — *know*
- three roots and their English kin — *gam/come, ad/eat, paś/inspect*

Before you move on

What is the root of *jñāti*, and what does its class insert? (ज्ञा *jñā*; the syllable -ना-.) Give the six verbs of this chapter. (*Asti, gacchati, āgacchati, khādati, paśyati, jñāti*.) Which two are one root plus a prefix? (गच्छति and आगच्छति.) Which Sanskrit root is English *know*? (ज्ञा.) And which English words carry *gam, ad, paś, and bhū*? (*Come, eat, inspect, be* — four roots you now own in two languages.)

Chapter 8

The Mind and the Palm Leaf

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone thinks, understands, reads and writes in Sanskrit; I can name the class that plants -अय- inside a verb, build “understands” out of a prefix and a verb I already had, say what लिख् meant before it meant write, and tell a word worn down by speech (तद्भव) from one carried over whole (तत्सम).

Say लिखति, give the scratching sense its root carried first, run the chapter’s four verbs back as root plus class plus ending — the planted -अय- of चिन्तयति, the अव- prefix and the waking बुध् behind understanding, the plain -a- of पठति and लिखति — sort Bengali lekhā and Hindi cintā into तद्भव and तत्सम, and name the two word-histories that needed a label rather than a claim.

8.1 चिन्तयति (cintayati) — “thinks,” and a root that never reached English

Say “it knows.” (Jānāti, root ज्ञा — the root English know is made of.) Here is what you do *before* you know.

You’ll want to know: चिन्तयति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
चिन्तयति	cintayati	he, she, or it thinks
चिन्ता	cintā	a thought , a worry

The root is चिन्त् (cint), “to think, to turn over.” Chapter 3 already handed you the noun: न चिन्ता (na cintā), “no worry,” is this root saying “think nothing of it.”

The letters in this word

चि is *ci*, said *chi* as in *chip*. Then न्त, न *na* stacked with त *ta* and said as one *nt*. य is *ya*, ति is *ti*: *chin-ta-ya-ti*.

Grammar Lens: the tenth class plants अय

Three ways a गण class has turned a root into a present stem: add nothing (*as-ti*), add a vowel (*bhava-ti*), plant a syllable inside (*jā-nā-ti*). Here is the fourth.

The **tenth** class inserts **-अय-** (*-aya-*) between root and ending: *cint* + *aya* + *ti* → चिन्तयति. The marker is loud and always in the same position, so *-aya-* names its class on hearing.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

चिन्त् goes back to PIE **kweyt-*, “to notice” — and its च *c-* is the rounded *k* from the numbers, which Indo-Iranian merged with plain *k* and then palatalised before a front vowel.

Where it went next is the surprise. Baltic and Slavic took “notice” to “count” and then to **read**: Russian *čitat* and Lithuanian *skaityti* both mean “to read.” Sanskrit made the same root mean *think*.

And English? Nothing descends from **kweyt-*. The trail west runs out, and saying so beats inventing a cousin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cintayati” — it thinks
- the root and its planted syllable — *cint* ... *aya*
- the Chapter 3 phrase built on the same root — *na cintā*

Before you move on

What does class 10 put between root and ending, and what is *cintayati*’s root? (**-अय-**; चिन्त्, the root of *na cintā*.) Why does the word begin with *c* and not *k*? (**A rounded PIE *k*, merged and then palatalised** — the numbers’ rule.) Which verb of knowing came just before this one, and does *cint* have an English cousin? (जानाति; **no** —

this root left English nothing.)

8.2 अवगच्छति (avagacchati) — “understands,” going down into it

Say “it goes,” then “it comes.” (*Gacchati*, *āgacchati* — one उपसर्ग prefix apart.) And say “it thinks.” (*Cintayati*.) One more prefix, and thinking turns into understanding.

You’ll want to know: अवगच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गच्छति	<i>gacchati</i>	it goes
अवगच्छति	<i>avagacchati</i>	it understands

अव (*ava*) means “down.” Put it on “goes” and you get “goes down into” — and that is Sanskrit’s ordinary verb for understanding. No new root, no new stem: one more preverb on a word you already own.

Sanskrit has a second verb for it too, बुध्यते (*budhyate*), “wakes, comes to realise.” Its ending -ते *-te* belongs to Sanskrit’s second set of endings, used when the action loops back on the doer — waking is something you do to yourself.

The letters in this word

Everything after two syllables is last chapter’s word. The new opening is अ *a* plus व *va*: *a-va-gach-cha-ti*. In बुध्यते the middle is ध्य, a stack of ध *dha* and य *ya*, said glued: *bu-dhya-te*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

गम्, under *avagacchati*, is still PIE **gwem-*, the root of English **come** and Latin *venīre* behind **advent**.

बुध् is PIE **bheudh-*, “to be awake, to be aware.” Its most famous derivative is बुद्ध (*buddha*), “the awakened one” — a title, not a name. Greek made it *punthanomai*, “to learn by asking”; Russian *budit* still means “to wake.”

English got it too, worn thin: **forbid** and **bode** (as in *foreboding*) descend from Old English *bēodan*, “to announce, to offer.” Modern *bid*

mixes that verb with a second, unrelated one — so keep to *forbid* and *bode* if you want the clean cousin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gacchati ... avagacchati” — goes, understands
- the prefix and its sense — *ava*, down
- the other verb and its root — *budhyate*, *budh*
- what बुद्ध means — the awakened one

Before you move on

Build “understands” out of pieces you already had. (अव “down” + गच्छति “goes”.) Name the three verbs that share that one stem. (*Gacchati*, *āgacchati*, *avagacchati*.) What does बुध् mean before it means “understand,” and what title comes from it? (**To wake**; बुद्ध, the awakened one.) Which two English words are its clean cousins? (**Forbid** and **bode**.)

8.3 पठति (paṭhati) — “reads,” and where the word went afterwards

Say “it thinks” and “it understands.” (*Cintayati*, *avagacchati*.)
This next verb is the plainest build in the chapter and the richest afterlife.

You’ll want to know: पठति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पठति	<i>paṭhati</i>	he, she, or it reads
पाठ	<i>pāṭha</i>	a lesson , a recitation

The root is पठ् (*paṭh*), class 1 — root, vowel, ending, exactly like *bhavati*. Its first meaning is not “read” but “**recite aloud, rehearse, study**”: reading was a thing done with the mouth, and Sanskrit named it that way.

The letters in this word

प is *pa*. ठ is *ṭha*, a *t* made with the tongue curled back to the roof of the mouth *and* a puff of breath after it. ति is *ti*, tongue forward. Hear the two *t*-sounds apart: *pa-ṭha-ti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

This is the verb four living languages still read with — Hindi and Urdu *paṛhnā*, Bengali *pora*, Marathi *paḍhṇe*. The change is regular: that curled-back ठ softens between vowels, and the old ending drops off. A word reshaped by centuries of ordinary speech is तद्भव (*tadbhava*), “become from that.”

Now set चिन्ता beside it. It sits in Hindi, Marathi and Bengali **unchanged** — lifted back out of Sanskrit by scholars rather than inherited through speech. That kind is तत्सम (*tatsama*), “the same as that.” Every claim about a Sanskrit word’s descendants is one of those two, and they are not the same claim.

Grammar Lens: where पठति itself came from

The usual account runs back through प्रथ् (*prath*), “to spread, to become widely known” — reciting as broadcasting — and behind that a root that also gives पृथिवी (*pr̥thivī*), “the earth, the wide one.”

Some hold instead that *paṭhati* is a later, spoken form that scholars dressed up as Sanskrit. Keep the label on it, exactly as you did with *punch*: a common account, not a settled one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*paṭhati*” — it reads, it recites
- a worn-down grandchild — *paṛhnā*
- a word carried whole — *cintā*

Before you move on

What did *paṭhati* mean before “read,” and which class builds it? (**Recite aloud; class 1.**) Name the two ways a Sanskrit word reaches a modern language. (तद्भव, worn down through speech; तत्सम, carried

over whole.) Which is *paṛhnā*, which is *cintā*, and what label belongs on *paṭhati*'s own ancestry? (*Tadbhava*; *tatsama*; **a common account, not settled** — the caution you kept on *punch*.)

8.4 लिखति (likhati) — “writes,” and the scratch it started as

Say “it reads.” (*Paṭhati*.) Name a language that still reads with that word. (Hindi *paṛhnā*, Bengali *poṛa*, Marathi *paḍhṇe* — any one.) Now the other half of literacy.

You’ll want to know: लिखति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
लिखति	<i>likhati</i>	he, she, or it writes
लेखनी	<i>lekhanī</i>	a pen

The root is लिख् (*likh*), class 6. Class 6 adds the same *-a-* class 1 does but leaves the root untouched: *likh* + *a* + *ti*. Two classes, one vowel, and the difference is only whether the root gets strengthened first.

The letters in this word

लि is *li*. ख is *kha*, a *k* with a puff of breath after it — the letter that opens *khādati*. ति is *ti*: *li-kha-ti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

लिख् does not mean “write” first. It means **to scratch, to scrape, to furrow**, and “write” second — because writing *was* scratching, into palm leaf and birch bark with a stylus. The older sense stays visible in रेखा (*rekhā*), “a line, a scratch,” the same root wearing an *r*.

Outside Sanskrit the trail is thin but real: Greek *ereikō*, “to tear,” and Lithuanian *riekti*, “to slice.” No everyday English word descends from it — that is two roots in this chapter that left English nothing.

Eastward, a different story: Hindi and Urdu *likhnā*, Bengali *lekhā*, Marathi *lihṇe* — worn down, *tadbhava*, with Marathi’s *kh* softened to *h*.

What you’ve built: four verbs, four ways to build a stem

Cintayati, avagacchati, paṭhati, likhati. Thinking plants -अय-; understanding is “goes” with अव in front, or बुध्यते, waking; reading and writing take a plain -a-, class 1 and class 6.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “likhati” — it writes
- what the root meant first — to scratch
- the chapter’s four — *cintayati, avagacchati, paṭhati, likhati*

Before you move on

What did लिख् mean before “write,” and what are the chapter’s four verbs? (**To scratch**; *cintayati, avagacchati, paṭhati, likhati.*) Which plants -अय-, and which is a prefix on a verb you already had? (*Cintayati; avagacchati.*) Which verb of understanding means “wakes,” and what title comes from its root? (बुध्यते; बुद्ध.) Is Bengali *lekhā* tatsama or tadbhava, and which two word-histories here needed a label rather than a claim? (**Tadbhava**; *paṭhati*’s ancestry and *likh*’s English kin — the *punch* caution, twice.)

Chapter 9

Taking, Asking, Helping, Loving

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone takes, asks, helps and loves in Sanskrit; I can say संस्कृतं मम प्रियम्, build a verb by putting करोति behind a noun, and point at the English word — grab, pray, friend — that each of these four roots also produced.

Say संस्कृतं मम प्रियम्, give स्निग्ध its older sense of stickiness and label the disputed snow connection, follow प्रिय west into friend, free and Friday by the p-to-f change that also made pañca into five, run the chapter’s four verbs back with grab, pray and comes beside them, and sort प्रिय against Hindi piyā as तत्सम against तद्भव — then place पञ्च beside प्रिय as the other word that travelled in both directions at once.

9.1 गृह्णाति (grhṇāti) — “takes,” and English *grab*

Say “it writes,” and what its root meant first. (*Likhati*; **to scratch**.) Now say “it knows” and name the syllable its class plants inside the word. (*Jānāti*; -ना-.) That syllable is back.

You’ll want to know: गृह्णाति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गृह्णाति	grhṇāti	he, she, or it takes , seizes
ग्रहण	grahaṇa	a seizing ; an eclipse

The root is ग्रह् (grah), class 9 — *jānāti*’s class. It plants the same syllable, and the syllable comes out -णा- rather than -ना-: a curled-back ऋ earlier in the word pulls the following *n* back to match it. Sanskrit tidies its consonants after the fact.

The letters in this word

गृ is *gr̥*: the vowel ऋ is a vowel made of *r* itself, a short buzz between *ri* and *ru* — the same vowel inside संस्कृत. Then ह्रा, *h* and curled-back *ṛ* fused with a long *ā*: *gr̥h-ṛā-ti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ग्रह् is PIE **ghrebh-*, “to seize.” The oldest Sanskrit still writes it गृह्णाति (*gr̥bhṇāti*), with the *bh* the reconstruction predicts. English kept the same root in **grab**, **grip** and **grasp**.

Say what that means carefully, though. Sanskrit built its verb with the class-9 syllable; English built its words with other endings entirely. They are the same root wearing different suffixes — **relatives, not the same word**, exactly the caution you put on *eka* beside *one*.

Inside Sanskrit the root spreads out: ग्रह (*graha*) is a **planet**, named as the *seizer* that takes hold of a life. Eastward it wore down to Marathi घेणे (*ghene*), the ordinary verb for taking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gr̥hṇāti” — it takes
- the root and its planted syllable — *grah ... ṛā*
- the English kin — *grab, grip, grasp*
- the worn-down Marathi grandchild — *ghene*

Before you move on

Which class builds *gr̥hṇāti*, and which earlier verb shares it? (**Class 9**; जानाति.) Why -णा- and not -ना-? (**The curled-back ऋ pulls the *n* back to match.**) Name three English words from the same root. (**Grab, grip, grasp.**) Are they the same word as *gr̥hṇāti* or relatives of it? (**Relatives** — same root, different suffixes, like *eka* and *one*.) Is Marathi *ghene* tatsama or tadbhava? (**Tadbhava.**)

9.2 पृच्छति (prcchati) — “asks,” and the prayer at the other end of it

Say “it takes” and its English kin. (*Gṛhṇāti*; **grab**.) Say “it goes.” (*Gacchati*.) Listen to the middle of that one — it comes back here.

You’ll want to know: पृच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पृच्छति	<i>prcchati</i>	he, she, or it asks
प्रश्न	<i>praśna</i>	a question

The root is प्रच्छ् (*prach*), class 6 — *likhati*’s class, a plain -a- on an untouched root. The root’s *r* turns into the vowel ऋ, and the ending fuses into the doubled च्छ you already met in *gacchati*.

The letters in this word

पृ is *pr*, the *r*-vowel again. च्छ is the stack of two *ch* sounds held slightly long, exactly as in *gacchati*. ति closes it: *prch-cha-ti*. Let the middle linger.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

प्रच्छ् is PIE **prek-*, “to ask,” and it is one of the best-travelled roots in the family.

Latin took it as *precārī*, “to ask, to entreat” — and from that English has **pray**, **prayer**, **deprecate**, and **precarious**, which meant “held only by asking, at someone else’s pleasure.”

Germanic took the same root and turned its initial *p* into *f* by **Grimm’s law** — the very change that made *pañca* into **five**. That is why German asks with **fragen**. Persian asks with *porsidan* and Russian with *prosit*, both the same word again.

Eastward it wore down: Hindi and Urdu पूछना (*pūchnā*), Marathi पुसणे (*pusṇe*) — *tadbhava*, with the *r*-vowel flattened to *u*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “prcchati” — it asks

- the root — *prach*
- the Latin descendant and its English children — *precārī*, *pray*
- the German cousin with *f* — *fragen*

Before you move on

Which class builds *prcchati*, and which verb shares its doubled middle? (**Class 6**; गच्छति.) What did Latin *precārī* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To entreat**; **pray**, **precarious**.) Why does German say *fragen* with an *f*? (**Grimm’s law turned initial *p* into *f*** — as in *pañca* and *five*.) And is Hindi *pūchnā* tatsama or tadbhava? (**Tadbhava**.)

9.3 साहाय्यं करोति (sāhāyyam karoti) — “helps,” or going along with

Say “it asks” and “it takes.” (*Prccchati*, *grhṇāti*.) Helping is not built like either of them. It takes two words.

You’ll want to know: साहाय्यं करोति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
साहाय्यम्	<i>sāhāyyam</i>	help , assistance
साहाय्यं करोति	<i>sāhāyyam karoti</i>	he, she, or it helps

करोति (*karoti*) is “does, makes” — the root कृ (*kr*), class 8, yours since Chapter 5 as करोमि (*karomi*), “I do.” Same stem, familiar swap of ending: -ति for “he, she, it,” -मि for “I.”

So Sanskrit has no verb “to help.” It has a noun for help and puts “does” behind it — a machine you can run on almost any noun.

The letters in this word

सा *sā*, हा *hā*, then य्य, य *ya* stacked on itself and held double. The final म् *m* softens to a hum before the next word, so it is written ः: *sāhāyyam karoti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

साहाय्य is built on सहाय (*sahāya*), “a companion” — सह (*saha*), “with,” plus आय, from the root इ (*i*), “to go.” A helper is *one who goes along with you*. Sanskrit leaves such seams showing, the way संस्कृत is *sam* “together” on कृ.

Latin names a companion by the same picture: *comes* is *com-* “with” on *ire* “to go,” the root behind **exit** and **transit**.

Bengali still helps with this very word, unchanged: *sāhājjo korā*, a *tat-sama* carrying the whole Sanskrit noun plus its own “do.” Hindi and Marathi instead say *madad karnā* and *madat karṇe* — same machine, but with an **Arabic** word that reached them through Persian. Not everything modern comes from Sanskrit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāhāyyam karoti” — it helps
- “karomi ... karoti” — I do, it does
- the two pieces of *sahāya* — *saha* “with,” *āya* “going”

Before you move on

How does Sanskrit say “helps”? (साहाय्यं करोति — a noun plus “does”.) What are the two pieces inside *sahāya*, and which Latin word for a companion is built the same way? (सह “with” + आय “going”; *comes*.) Which language still helps with this exact Sanskrit noun, and which two borrowed an Arabic one instead? (**Bengali; Hindi and Marathi**, with *madad*.)

9.4 स्निह्यति and प्रियम् — loving, and the word inside *friend*

Say “it helps,” “it asks,” “it takes.” (*Sāhāyyam karoti*, *prcchati*, *grhṇāti*.) One feeling left, named after something physical.

You'll want to know: स्निह्यति and प्रियम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
स्निह्यति	<i>snihyati</i>	he, she, or it feels affection
मम प्रियम्	<i>mama priyam</i>	dear to me

स्निह् (*sni*) means, first, **to be sticky, oily, moist**, and only then “to feel fond of.” The noun स्नेह (*sneha*) is still both: *oil* and *affection*.

For everyday liking Sanskrit reaches instead for प्रिय (*priya*), “dear.” With मम (*mama*), yours since Chapter 2: संस्कृतं मम प्रियम्, “Sanskrit is dear to me.”

The letters in this word

स्नि stacks स *sa* on न *na* over the vowel *i* — one push, *sni*, not *si-ni*. Then ह्य, *h* and *y* fused: *sni**h-ya-ti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

प्रिय is PIE **priHos*, “dear, beloved.” Germanic turned that *p* into *f* by Grimm’s law — the third time you have watched it happen: **friend** is “the loving one,” **free** meant “beloved of the household” before “not a slave,” and **Friday** is the day of *Frigg*, whose name is the same word. Eastward it took both roads at once: प्रिय sits unchanged in Hindi, Marathi and Bengali, a *tatsama*; worn down it is Hindi पिया (*piyā*), “beloved,” a *tadbhava*.

स्निह् is the opposite case. It may belong with the root behind **snow** — snow being what sticks — but that is argued, so keep it labelled.

What you’ve built: four verbs, and a taproot

Gṛhṇāti, *pr̥cchati*, *sāhāyāni karoti*, *snihyati* — seizing, asking, going along with, sticking. Four physical pictures, each reaching west (*grab*, *pray*, *comes*, *friend*) and east into living speech.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “saṁskṛtaṁ mama priyam” — Sanskrit is dear to me
- स्नेह, twice over — oil, and affection

- *friend, free, Friday* — all from *priya*

Before you move on

Give this chapter's four, and what स्निह् meant before "love." (*Gṛhṇāti, pr̥cchati, sāhāyyam karoti, snihyati*; **sticky, oily**.) Three English words from प्रिय, and what turned its *p* into *f*? (**Friend, free, Friday**; **Grimm's law**, as in *fragen* and *five*.) Which English number's *f* is **not** that law? (**Four**, copying *five*.) Which earlier word travelled both ways as *priya* does, and is *piyā* tatsama or tadbhava? (पञ्च — east to *pañj* and **Punjab**, "five waters," west to Greek *pente*; *piyā* is **tadbhava**.)

Chapter 10

What You’d Ask For

By the end of this chapter: I can name water, milk and food in Sanskrit, say that food is grammatically the eaten thing, and name the three genders every Sanskrit noun carries.

Say अन्नम्, name the root अद् it shares with खादति’s cousin अत्ति, and state the three grammatical genders Sanskrit sorts every noun into, tying the neuter -म् running through the chapter back to the neuter numeral forms of Chapter 6.

10.1 पानीयम् (pānīyam) — “water,” the thing to be drunk

Say “Sanskrit is dear to me.” (*Samiskṛtaṁ mama priyam.*) Every word so far has named an action. Now for the nouns you would actually reach for — starting with the one you would ask for first.

You’ll want to know: पानीयम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पानीयम्	<i>pānīyam</i>	water
पिबति	<i>pibati</i>	he, she, or it drinks

पानीयम् is neuter, and its final -म् marks that — a whole family of everyday nouns ends this way, and it will keep coming back this chapter.

The letters in this word

पा is *pā*, the long-*ā* you have said since नाम. नी stacks न *na* under the long-*i* sign ी. यम् closes it: *y*, the inherent *a*, then म् with its vowel stripped by the *halant* — *pā-nī-ya-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पानीयम् is built on the root पा (*pā*), “to drink,” plus -अनीय (*-anīya*), a suffix meaning “fit to be ~ed.” Literally: **the thing that is to be drunk**.

The root is PIE **peh3-**, “to drink.” Latin took it into *potare*, and from that English has **potion** and **poison** — a drink, and a drink gone wrong. Eastward, पानीयम् wore down through Prakrit *pāṇīya* into the everyday water-word of the daughter languages: Hindi पानी (*pānī*), Gujarati *pāṇī*, and, in the Bangladesh register of Bengali, *pani* — every one तद्भव, worn down by ordinary speech, not carried over whole. Sanskrit’s own oldest water-words, जल and उदक, took a different road entirely; this is not that word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pānīyam*” — water
- the root and its suffix — *pā* “drink” plus *-anīya* “fit to be”
- the worn-down grandchildren — *pānī*, *pāṇī*, *pani*

Before you move on

What does पानीयम् literally mean, and from which two pieces? (“**The thing to be drunk**” — *pā* “drink” plus *-anīya* “fit to be”.) Name two English words from the same PIE root. (**Potion, poison.**) Is Hindi *pānī* तत्सम or तद्भव? (तद्भव.) And how did you say “dear to me” last chapter? (*Priyam.*)

10.2 क्षीरम् (kṣīram) — “milk,” and the dessert it left behind

Say “water,” and the root it is built on. (*Pānīyam*; पा, “to drink.”) Not every drink-word in Sanskrit has so tidy an answer.

You’ll want to know: क्षीरम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
क्षीरम्	<i>kṣīram</i>	milk
क्षीर	<i>kṣīra</i>	milk — the bare stem, still living inside Hindi <i>khīr</i>

Neuter again, marked by the same -म् as पानीयम्.

The letters in this word

क्ष is a new stacked pair: क *k* fused under ष, the hissed retroflex *s* — together they say *kṣa*, one push, not two. Then the long-ī sign ी, र *ra*, and the neuter म् you already know: *kṣī-ra-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where पानीयम्’s history is settled, क्षीरम्’s is not. One account traces it to an old Proto-Indo-European word for milk; another argues it was borrowed from a substrate language spoken where Indo-Iranian speakers first arrived in the region. Neither side has won.

What is clear is the family it sits in: Avestan **xšuuīdi-** and Persian *šīr* say roughly the same word, but as **relatives**, not children — all three come down from one shared Proto-Indo-Iranian ancestor, the way *grhṇāti* and English *grab* are cousins rather than the same word wearing different clothes.

The word’s liveliest descendant is not a drink. Hindi खीर (*khīr*) is a sweet rice pudding cooked in milk — worn down, तद्भव — and English borrowed that dessert whole, as **kheer**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kṣīram” — milk
- the two disputed accounts — an old root, or a borrowed one
- the dessert it became — *khīr*, borrowed into English as *kheer*

Before you move on

Is क्षीरम्'s own origin settled or disputed? (**Disputed** — inherited, or borrowed from a substrate.) Are Persian *šīr* and Sanskrit *kṣīram* parent and child, or relatives? (**Relatives**, from one shared ancestor.) What English word for a dessert comes from Hindi *khīr*? (**Kheer**.) And what does *pānīyam* literally mean? (“**The thing to be drunk.**”)

10.3 अन्नम् (annam) — “food,” the eaten thing

Say “milk” and “water.” (*Kṣīram*, *pānīyam*.) One more thing you would ask for, and this one carries a root you already own.

You'll want to know: अन्नम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
अन्नम्	<i>annam</i>	food, grain
खाद्यम् अन्नम्	<i>khādyam annam</i>	edible food — खादति's own adjective on it

Neuter, and -म् again — the third noun running.

The letters in this word

अ opens bare, no consonant to carry it. न्न doubles न *na* onto itself, held a beat longer than one *n* would be. म् closes it, the same stripped-vowel neuter ending: *an-na-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Chapter 7 taught खादति, the everyday word for eating, and set beside it its untaken cousin: अद्, PIE *ed-*, the very root of English *eat*, which Sanskrit keeps alive as अत्ति.

अन्नम् is built on that same अद्, plus the old participle suffix -न — “eaten.” The *d* and the *n* fuse into the doubled न्न you just sounded out. Food, named this way, is not a thing but an **event**: the thing that has been eaten.

Grammar Lens: three genders, one small system

Every noun in this chapter has ended in -न्, and that is not coincidence: Sanskrit sorts every noun into one of **three genders** — masculine, feminine, and neuter — the same system that put a gendered form on the numerals back in Chapter 6, where the daughter languages inherited specifically the **neuter** forms, *trīṇi* and *catvāri*. This book teaches only the plain nominative singular of each noun, never the full run of cases and numbers behind it — but the gender is worth carrying, because it is not optional, and it is not guessable from meaning alone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “annam” — food
- the root and its participle — *ad* “eat” plus *-na* “eaten”
- the three genders — masculine, feminine, neuter

Before you move on

What does *annam* literally mean, and which root is it built on? (“**Eaten**”; अद्, the cousin of English *eat*.) Which everyday verb shares that root without being it? (*Khādati*.) Which gender have all three nouns this chapter shared? (**Neuter**, marked by -न्.) And which gendered form did the numerals hand the daughter languages back in Chapter 6? (**The neuter one** — *trīṇi*, *catvāri*.) Name this chapter’s three words. (*Pānīyam*, *kṣīram*, *annam* — the things you would ask for.)

Chapter 11

The People You'd Introduce

By the end of this chapter: I can name a friend, a family, a brother and a sister in Sanskrit, and say which of those words travelled with English and which quietly did not.

Say भगिनी, name the share-word भग it is built on, name स्वस् as the real but non-living PIE cousin of English sister, and run the chapter's four people back together with the roads each one travelled.

11.1 मित्रम् (mitram) — “friend,” and the god of the given word

Say “food,” and its gender. (*Annam*; **neuter**.) The last three words named things you would ask for. This one names someone you would introduce.

You'll want to know: मित्रम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
मित्रम्	<i>mitram</i>	friend
मित्रम् मम	<i>mitram mama</i>	my friend

The letters in this word

मि is *mi*, a short vowel sign under म. त्र stacks त *ta* under र *ra*, said as one push, *tra*. म् closes it, neuter again: *mi-tra-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मित्रम् comes from Proto-Indo-Iranian ***mitras**, “that which causes binding” — a promise, a pact, a bond between two people. The same word names **Mithra**, the Avestan and Zoroastrian god of covenant and contract: a friendship, at the root, is a kind of oath.

It travelled east with almost no change at all: Hindi and Marathi मित्र, Gujarati *mitra*, all तत्सम, lifted straight out of Sanskrit rather than worn down the way पानीयम् became *pānī*.

Grammar Lens: a person, grammatically neuter

Here is the proof that gender is not about meaning. मित्रम् names a person, and Sanskrit still marks it **neuter** — the same -म् you have now seen on water, milk, and food. A noun's gender is a fact about the *word*, inherited with its shape, not a fact about who or what it points to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mitram” — friend
- the god it shares a name with — *Mithra*
- three languages that kept it whole — Hindi, Marathi, Gujarati

Before you move on

What does the root behind मित्रम् mean, and what god shares it? (“**To bind**”; **Mithra**, the covenant god.) Is मित्र in Hindi तत्सम or तद्भव? (तत्सम.) What gender is *mitram*, and why is that surprising? (**Neuter** — it names a person, but gender tracks the word's class, not the person.)

11.2 कुटुम्बम् (kuṭumbam) — “family,” a word that made a round trip

Say “friend,” and its gender. (*Mitram*; **neuter**.) One person's name, now the group everyone belongs to.

You'll want to know: कुटुम्बम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
कुटुम्बम्	<i>kuṭumbam</i>	family , household
मम कुटुम्बम्	<i>mama kuṭumbam</i>	my family

The letters in this word

कु is *ku*, a short-*u* sign under क. टु repeats it under the curled-back ट, the retroflex *t* you first met in संस्कृत's neighbours. म्ब stacks ब *ba* under a silent म्, and a final म् closes it: *ku-ṭu-mba-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Every etymology so far in this chapter has run from Sanskrit outward. This one runs the other way first. कुटुम्बम् is a loanword **into** Sanskrit from a Dravidian language, compared to Tamil **kuṭimai**, “family, lineage, allegiance,” itself built on **kuṭi**, “a hut, a settlement.” A family, on this account, is literally *those who share one roof*.

From Sanskrit the finished word travelled onward as a formal, learned तत्सम — Hindi कुटुंब and Bengali *kuṭumbo* — and then made a full circle: Kannada, Telugu and Tamil today all hold this same Sanskrit-shaped form, borrowed back into languages that, on one account, lent Sanskrit the word in the first place.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kuṭumbam” — family
- which family lent Sanskrit the word — Dravidian
- the languages that later borrowed it back — Kannada, Telugu, Tamil

Before you move on

Which direction did कुटुम्बम् travel first — into Sanskrit, or out of it? (**Into it** — a Dravidian loanword.) What Tamil word is it compared to, and what does it literally build on? (**kuṭimai**, “family, lineage,” on **kuṭi**, “a hut.”) Which languages later borrowed the Sanskrit-

shaped form back? (**Kannada, Telugu, Tamil.**)

11.3 भ्राता (bhrātā) — “brother,” the same word, worn two ways

Say “family” and “friend.” (*Kuṭumbam, mitram.*) Now for the first person inside that family — and the plainest cousin in this book yet.

You'll want to know: भ्राता

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
भ्राता	<i>bhrātā</i>	brother
मम भ्राता	<i>mama bhrātā</i>	my brother

Masculine — the first noun this chapter has not ended in -म्.

The letters in this word

भ्रा stacks र *ra* under भ *bha*, one push, then the long-ā: *bhrā*. ता closes it, *ta* plus long-ā again: *bhrā-tā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

भ्राता is PIE **bhrāter-**, and the descent is about as unbroken as this family gets: English **brother**, Latin **frāter**, Greek **phrātēr** are not relatives of भ्राता — they **are** भ्राता, six thousand years and three different roads later.

One of those roads runs straight through the daughter languages. भ्राता wore down through Prakrit *bhāi* into Bengali *bhāi* and Gujarati *bhāi*, both तद्भव — the same word again, just worn smooth by everyday speech rather than lifted whole like मित्र.

Grammatically, भ्राता is a fossil of its own: an old kinship word built on the stem भ्रातृ (*bhrātr*), whose nominative singular lengthens the final vowel to -आ instead of following the plain patterns you have seen so far.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhrātā” — brother
- its English, Latin, and Greek selves — brother, frāter, phrātēr
- its worn-down grandchildren — *bhāi*, *bhāi*

Before you move on

Is English *brother* a cousin of भ्राता, or the same word? (**The same word**, unbroken from PIE.) Which two daughter languages wore it down to *bhāi*? (**Bengali, Gujarati.**) What gender is भ्राता, unlike every noun before it this chapter? (**Masculine.**)

11.4 भगिनी (bhaginī) — “sister,” one with a share

Say “brother,” and name the English word it is not a cousin of but literally **is**. (*Bhrātā*; **brother.**) The matching word does not tell the same story.

You’ll want to know: भगिनी

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
भगिनी	<i>bhaginī</i>	sister
मम भगिनी	<i>mama bhaginī</i>	my sister

Feminine — marked by the -ई you can hear at the end.

The letters in this word

भ is *bha*. गि is ग *ga* under a short-*i* sign. नी closes it, न under the long-*ī* sign — the same feminine ending you will meet again this book: *bha-gi-nī*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here the pattern breaks. भगिनी is built on भग (*bhaga*), “a share, good fortune,” plus the feminine suffix -इनी: literally, “one with a share.” Sanskrit’s actual cousin of English **sister** is a different word, स्वसृ (*svasr*), from the same PIE root as *bhrātā*’s. It is real, attested in the old texts — but it did not become the everyday word. भगिनी did, and भगिनी is what wore down eastward: Bengali *bon* and Gujarati *bahen*, both तद्धव, both built on भग, not स्वसृ.

So the honest connection to draw for “sister” is not the one nearest to English. Brother and sister do not travel the same road here — one is the same word worn down; the other took a different word entirely and left the matching one behind.

What you’ve built: four people

Mitram, kuṭumbam, bhrātā, bhaginī — a friend, a family, a brother, a sister. One borrowed into Sanskrit and then borrowed back out; two travelled in lockstep with their English match; one quietly swapped words along the way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhaginī” — sister
- what it is built on — *bhaga* “a share” plus *-inī*
- the word it is NOT built on — *svasṛ*, the real cousin of *sister*

Before you move on

What does भगिनी literally mean? (“**One with a share.**”) What is the actual PIE cousin of English *sister*, and why is it not the word we learned? (स्वसृ — attested, but never the living word.) Which two daughter languages descend from भगिनी instead? (**Bengali, Gujarati.**) Name this chapter’s four people. (*Mitram, kuṭumbam, bhrātā, bhaginī*.)

Chapter 12

The Face, Part One

By the end of this chapter: I can name an eye, an ear and a mouth in Sanskrit, say why eyes take a dual number, and say which of the three words has a settled Western cousin and which do not.

Say मुखम्, report both scholarly accounts of its origin without choosing between them, and run अक्षि, कर्णः and मुखम् back together against their daughter-language descendants and the neuter gender most of them share.

12.1 अक्षि (akṣi) — “eye,” and the number Sanskrit built for it

Say “sister.” (*Bhagin̄*.) The people you would introduce are done. Now for the face you would check on someone with.

You’ll want to know: अक्षि

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
अक्षि	<i>akṣi</i>	eye
अक्षिणी	<i>akṣiṇī</i>	the two eyes

Neuter, like most of this book’s shortest nouns.

The letters in this word

अ opens bare. क्षि is the same क्ष conjunct you sounded out in क्षीरम्, now carrying a short-*i* instead of a long one: *a-kṣi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अक्षि is PIE **h₃ekw-**, and the descent runs almost as clean as *bhrātā*'s: English **eye**, Latin **oculus** (→ *ocular*, *monocle*), Lithuanian **akis** — one root, barely disguised anywhere. It carries straight into Hindi आँख and Gujarati āṅkh, both inherited, not borrowed back the way मित्र was. And eyes are exactly the reason Sanskrit keeps a **dual number** at all — the exactly-two form Chapter 6 built around द्वौ, “two,” rather than an ordinary count word. A single eye is अक्षि; the two you were born with are not a small plural, they are अक्षिणी — grammar built for a body that comes in pairs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akṣi” — eye
- its English and Latin selves — eye, oculus
- the dual form for two of them — *akṣiṇī*

Before you move on

Name two English words from the same root as अक्षि. (Eye, and, through Latin, **ocular** or **monocle**.) What is the dual form for “two eyes,” and what grammatical number is that? (अक्षिणी; the **dual**, the same category as *dvau*.) And what did you learn just before this? (*Bhaginī*, sister.)

12.2 कर्णः (karṇaḥ) — “ear,” a word without a settled parent

Say “eye,” and its dual form for two of them. (*Akṣi*; **akṣiṇī**.)

The next sense is one Sanskrit itself never traced to its source.

You'll want to know: कर्णः

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
कर्णः	<i>karṇah</i>	ear
कर्णौ	<i>karṇau</i>	the two ears — dual again

Masculine, unlike अक्षि.

The letters in this word

कर् is *kar*, the *r* you have sounded since संस्कृत. ण is the curled-back retroflex *n*, familiar from गृह्णाति. The final ः, a *visarga*, breathes the word out on an echo of its own vowel: *kar-ṇa-h*, the same puff first heard closing नमस्ते.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where अक्षि's ancestry runs clean back to PIE, कर्णः's does not run anywhere agreed. Proposed roots mean “a defect,” “a point,” “a handle,” and “to hear” — and no single account has won out over the others. What is certain is where it went. कर्णः wore down through Prakrit **kaṇṇa** into Gujarati *kān* — and changed gender on the way: masculine in Sanskrit, feminine in Gujarati. A word can cross a language boundary and lose the very grammar that first classified it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “karṇah” — ear
- the four disputed guesses — a defect, a point, a handle, to hear
- the daughter word and its new gender — *kān*, now feminine

Before you move on

Is कर्णः's root settled or disputed? (**Disputed** — four guesses, no winner.) What ending marks it masculine, and where did you meet that sound before? (-अः, a *visarga*, first heard on नमस्ते.) What gender does the Gujarati descendant *kān* take, and is that the same as Sanskrit's? (**Feminine** — it changed.)

12.3 मुखम् (mukham) — “mouth,” a word two families both claim

Say “ear” and “eye.” (*Karṇaḥ, akṣi.*) One more, and this one’s ancestry is argued over by two whole language families, not just two scholars.

You’ll want to know: मुखम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
मुखम्	<i>mukham</i>	mouth , face
सम्मुखम्	<i>sammukham</i>	face to face — सम् “together” plus मुखम्

Neuter, back to the family’s usual ending.

The letters in this word

मु is म under a short-*u* sign. ख is the aspirated *kha* you met in खादति — a *k* with a puff of breath, distinct from plain क. म् closes it: *mu-kha-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मुखम् is genuinely contested territory. One line of scholarship derives it from Dravidian; another argues for an Indo-European source, pointing to its presence in the Rigveda and in Iranian languages. Neither claim has settled the question, and this book takes no side either.

What is not contested is where it lives now. Bengali *mukh* keeps it whole, a तत्सम — while Gujarati holds a worn-down तद्भव doublet, **moḍhū**, alongside its own formal **mukh**. That is the same shape this book already showed with चिन्ता and पठति: one word, two roads into the same daughter language, once carried whole and once worn down by speech. मुखम् closes this chapter neuter, like every noun here but *bhrātā*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mukham” — mouth, face
- the two disputed families — Dravidian, or Indo-European

- its two Gujarati faces — *mukh*, and worn-down *moḍhũ*

Before you move on

Which two language families both claim मुखम्? (**Dravidian**, and **Indo-European** — unsettled.) Name मुखम्'s two Gujarati descendants and which is तत्सम, which तद्भव. (**mukh**, तत्सम; **moḍhũ**, तद्भव.) Name this chapter's three words for the face. (*Akṣi*, *karṇaḥ*, *mukham*.)

Chapter 13

The Face, Part Two

By the end of this chapter: I can name a nose and a heart in Sanskrit, say which daughter-language nose-word नासिका is a relative of rather than a parent of, and close the chapter's twelve nouns against the cousin words this book has already shown.

Say हृदयम्, name the PIE root it shares with heart, cor and kardia, place हृदयम् beside the same root's other independent inheritances, and run all twelve of this tranche's nouns back together by group and by gender.

13.1 नासिका (nāsikā) — “nose,” kin to two words but parent of neither

Say “mouth.” (*Mukham.*) One more part of the face — and a chance to correct a connection this book has not yet made carefully enough.

You'll want to know: नासिका

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
नासिका	<i>nāsikā</i>	nose
मम नासिका	<i>mama nāsikā</i>	my nose

Feminine, marked by the same -आ you will hear again.

The letters in this word

ना is *nā*, न under the long-*ā* sign. सि is स under a short-*i*. का closes it, क under long-*ā* again: *nā-si-kā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नासिका is built on an older word, नासा (*nāsā*), “nose,” plus the diminutive suffix -इका. नासा itself, and the still-older root नस् (*nas*) behind it, go back to PIE **nehas-**, the unbroken root of English **nose** and Latin **nasus** ($\rightarrow$ *nasal*).

Here is the correction worth making carefully: नासिका is *not* the ancestor of Bengali *nāk* or Gujarati *nāk*. Both of those wore straight down from नस् itself, through Prakrit **ṇakka**, by adding a completely different suffix. नासिका and नाक share a root, the way ग्रह् and English *grab* share one — **relatives, not parent and child**. Reaching for the nearest-looking Sanskrit word is not always reaching for the right ancestor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāsikā” — nose
- the older word and root beneath it — *nāsā*, *nas*
- the word नासिका is NOT the parent of — *nāk*

Before you move on

What PIE root is नासिका’s family from, and name two of its Western cousins. (**nehas-**; **nose**, **nasus/nasal**.) Is नासिका the ancestor of Bengali *nāk*, or its relative? (**Relative** — both descend from नस्, neither from the other.) What did you learn just before this? (*Mukham*, mouth.)

13.2 हृदयम् (*hṛdayam*) — “heart,” a root barely disguised anywhere

Say “nose,” “eye,” and “mouth.” (*Nāsikā*, *akṣi*, *mukham*.) One last word, and it names what this whole chapter has been checking on.

You'll want to know: हृदयम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
हृदयम्	<i>hṛdayam</i>	heart
मम हृदयम्	<i>mama hṛdayam</i>	my heart

Neuter — the family this whole chapter keeps returning to.

The letters in this word

हृ is *hr*: ह *ha* carrying the vocalic ऋ, the same buzzing vowel you first sounded out in गृह्णाति. द is *da*, य is *ya*, म् closes it neuter: *hṛ-da-ya-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

हृदयम् is PIE **kerd-**, and almost nothing about it has changed shape on the way anywhere: English **heart**, Latin **cor**, genitive **cordis** (→ *cordial*, *courage*, *accord*), Greek **kardia** (→ *cardiac*) — one root, four languages, all still recognisable. The same root anchors Italian **cuore**, Portuguese **coração**, and Russian *serdtse*, each an independent inheritance of the identical PIE ancestor rather than a loan from any of the others. Eastward, Bengali *hriday* keeps हृदयम् whole, a तत्सम; its worn-down twin *hiya* survives only in poetry and song, not everyday speech — the rarer pairing, where the carried-whole word is the common one and the worn-down word is the rare one.

What you've built: twelve words, three rooms

Three groups, twelve nouns: what you would ask for (*pānīyam*, *kṣīram*, *annam*), who you would introduce (*mitram*, *kuṭumbam*, *bhrātā*, *bhaginī*), and your own face (*akṣi*, *karṇaḥ*, *mukham*, *nāsikā*, *hṛdayam*). Almost every one of them ended in the neuter -म् you first named beside अन्नम् — and almost every one pointed at a word some other language in this project already teaches as its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hṛdayam” — heart
- four cousins across four languages — heart, cor, kardia, cuore

- the Bengali twin kept whole, and the one kept only in poetry —
hridoy, hiya

Before you move on

Name three languages, besides English, whose word for heart shares हृदयम्'s root. (Any three of **Latin, Greek, Italian, Portuguese, Russian.**) Which Bengali form of “heart” is everyday, and which survives only in poetry? (*hridoy*, everyday; *hiya*, poetry.) What gender has run through nearly this entire chapter's nouns? (**Neuter.**) And what was the very first word of this chapter? (*Pānīyam*, water.)

The Devanagari script and Sanskrit sounds — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system, with the points a Devanagari reader still needs for *Sanskrit*.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** क *ka*, न *na*, म *ma* — left to right under a connecting top line.
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** का *kā*, कि *ki*, की *kī*, कु *ku*, के *ke*, को *ko*. A standalone (word-initial) vowel has its own letter: अ *a*, आ *ā*, इ *i*...
3. **A *halant* removes the vowel**, and the bare consonant joins the next as a **conjunct**: स् + त → स्त, न + य → न्य.

What Sanskrit needs even from a Devanagari reader

- **The visarga ृ (ḥ).** A soft breathed echo of the preceding vowel at a word’s end — *namaskārah*, *rāmah*. It usually marks the masculine-singular ending, so it is grammatical as well as phonetic.
- **The anusvāra ँ (ṁ/ṅ).** A dot above the line nasalising the vowel or standing for a nasal consonant before another — very frequent in Sanskrit.
- **The vocalic ण ॠ (as in ṛgveda, “Rg Veda”).** Sanskrit treats ण as a *vowel* — it is the ण of *māṭṛ* “mother” and *pīṭṛ* “father,” the words that proved Sanskrit’s kinship with Latin *māter/pater* and English *mother/father*.

- **Sandhi.** Sanskrit fuses words at their seams by fixed sound-rules: *su* + *āgata* → *svāgata*. The lessons flag each fusion where it happens.

Sanskrit in the family

Sanskrit is the classical language of India — the tongue of the Vedas, of Kālidāsa, of Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain learning — and the ancestor of the modern Indo-Aryan languages (Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, Bengali, and more). It is a senior branch of **Indo-European**, sister to Greek, Latin, and the Germanic languages including English. That is why this book treats it, with Latin, as a *taproot*: its words reach both east into South Asia and west into Europe, and the lessons trace both directions.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

आगच्छति *āgacchati*

he, she, or it comes — the same verb as “goes” with a prefix pointing it homeward
Introduced in Chapter 7.

अक्षि *akṣi*

eye — unbroken from Sanskrit to English, and the reason eyes get their own grammatical number
Introduced in Chapter 12.

अन्नम् *annam*

food, grain — literally “the eaten thing,” built on the very root खादति left uneaten
Introduced in Chapter 10.

अस्ति · भवति *asti · bhavati*

is, and becomes — the two be-verbs Sanskrit keeps apart, and the root-plus-class system behind every Sanskrit verb
Introduced in Chapter 7.

अवगच्छति · बुध्यते *avagacchati · budhyate*

he, she, or it understands — “goes down into” a thing, or wakes up to it
Introduced in Chapter 8.

भगिनी *bhaginī*

sister — not built on English “sister”’s root at all, but on “one with a share”
Introduced in Chapter 11.

भ्राता *bhrātā*

brother — unbroken from Sanskrit to English, worn down two different ways
Introduced in Chapter 11.

चिन्तयति *cintayati*

he, she, or it thinks — the tenth class, which plants a whole syllable अय between root and ending
Introduced in Chapter 8.

एक द्व त्रि चतुर् पञ्च *eka dva tri catur pañca*

one to five — Old Indo-Aryan ancestors preserved in Sanskrit, and cousins of the English ones

Introduced in Chapter 6.

गच्छति *gacchati*

he, she, or it goes — the verb whose present stem you could never guess from its root

Introduced in Chapter 7.

गृह्णाति *grhṇāti*

he, she, or it takes, seizes — the ninth class again, and the root English grabs with

Introduced in Chapter 9.

हृदयम् *hṛdayam*

heart — the oldest, most secure cousin this book has shown, and kept whole two chapters east

Introduced in Chapter 13.

जानाति *jānāti*

he, she, or it knows — the root ज्ञा, the class that plants a syllable inside the verb, and the chapter's six roots gathered up

Introduced in Chapter 7.

कर्णः *karnah*

ear — a word Sanskrit itself never settled the origin of

Introduced in Chapter 12.

खादति *khādati*

he, she, or it eats — the everyday eat-verb, which is not the one English is related to

Introduced in Chapter 7.

क्षीरम् *kṣīram*

milk — an origin scholars still argue over, and the dessert word it left behind

Introduced in Chapter 10.

कुटुम्बम् *kuṭumbam*

family, household — a word Sanskrit itself borrowed, before other languages borrowed it back

Introduced in Chapter 11.

लिखति *likhati*

he, she, or it writes — a root that means “scratch,” and the chapter's four verbs gathered up

Introduced in Chapter 8.

मित्रम् *mitram*

friend — the word behind a covenant-god's name, naming a person while itself being neuter

Introduced in Chapter 11.

मुखम् *mukham*

mouth, face — a word so old, scholars still argue which family it belongs to
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नासिका *nāsikā*

nose — kin to two modern words, but the parent of neither
Introduced in Chapter 13.

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water — “the thing to be drunk,” and the exact word your neighbors’ पानी grew from
Introduced in Chapter 10.

पश्यति *paśyati*

he, she, or it sees — a verb assembled from two different roots, one of which you already met
Introduced in Chapter 7.

पठति *paṭhati*

he, she, or it reads — reading as reciting aloud, and the two ways a Sanskrit word survives into a modern language
Introduced in Chapter 8.

पृच्छति *prcchati*

he, she, or it asks — the root that became Latin prayer and German fragen
Introduced in Chapter 9.

साहाय्यं करोति *sāhāyyaṃ karoti*

he, she, or it helps — a noun plus “does,” and help named as going along with someone
Introduced in Chapter 9.

स्निह्यति · प्रियम् *snihyati · priyam*

he, she, or it loves, and what is dear — affection named as stickiness, and the word behind English friend
Introduced in Chapter 9.

अस्ति

is
Introduced in Chapter 2.

अहं संस्कृतं वदामि

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Introduced in Chapter 5.

अहम्

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Introduced in Chapter 3.

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joy — and “meeting you is a joy”
Introduced in Chapter 2.

आम् / न

yes / no (ām / na)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

कथम्

how

Introduced in Chapter 3.

किम्

what

Introduced in Chapter 2.

करोमि

I do, I make (कार्यं करोमि, “I work”)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

कुशलम्

well-being — and the reply “अहं कुशली अस्मि”

Introduced in Chapter 3.

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I go (a way to take leave)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

तव नाम किम्?

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Introduced in Chapter 2.

धन्यवादः

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Introduced in Chapter 1.

न चिन्ता

no worry / it’s nothing / you’re welcome

Introduced in Chapter 3.

नाम

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

नमस्कारः

hello (lit. “the making of a bow”) (namaskārah)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

नमस्ते

hello (lit. “a bow to you”) (namaste)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

पुनः

again

Introduced in Chapter 4.

पुनर्दर्शनाय

until we meet again (lit. “for seeing again”)

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भवान् / त्वम्

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Introduced in Chapter 2.

भवान् कथम् अस्ति?

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Introduced in Chapter 3.

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my
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मम नाम ... अस्ति

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Introduced in Chapter 2.

वदामि

I speak (from वद्, to speak)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

वसामि

I live, I dwell (from वस्, to dwell)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

श्वः

tomorrow — and “see you tomorrow”
Introduced in Chapter 4.

स्वागतम्

welcome (lit. “well come”) (svāgatam)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 6

6.1 *The Sanskrit numbers are English cousins*

Were the Latin and Sanskrit number forms borrowed from one another?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 6

6.1 *The Sanskrit numbers are English cousins*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no they were not; they are inherited cousins; inherited cousins

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

A

again पुनः

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

B

brother — unbroken from Sanskrit to English, worn down two different ways भ्राता (bhrātā)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 11, p. 61

E

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explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

M**milk — an origin scholars still argue over, and the dessert word****it left behind क्षीरम् (kṣīram)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 55

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***Pañca* hiding in familiar words**
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sister — not built on English “sister”’s root at all, but on “one with a share” भगिनी (bhaginī)
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